

PART 3 Reading Comprehension

In this section of the test, you will read some texts and answer 42 questions. Choose the correct answer to each question and mark the letter of the correct answer on your answer sheet.

Questions 1-6 are about the following topic.

Modern life is about progress and development. As human beings, we're supposed to improve, to become smarter with each generation. Now, while that may be true in a comparison with prehistoric people, there is an increasing amount of evidence that human beings of our era – people just like you and me – are in danger of going backwards, not forwards. The experts say that certain aspects of modern life are tiring our brains, making them slower, more stupid and less capable of original thought. What are we doing wrong? Quite a lot, actually.



Let's begin with food. There is plenty of evidence that eating the huge amounts of the fats that are found in junk food negatively affects motivation. Motivation is a key ingredient in an active brain. Not having the enthusiasm to study, read for enjoyment, and go out or play sport can lead to a more sedentary lifestyle, the life of a couch potato, happy only to sit in front of a TV, watching shows that are as rubbish as the food you eat. As if that isn't bad enough, fatty diets can also damage your memory and lead to depression. Seriously, are those French fries worth it?

Another feature of modern life that affects our brains is multitasking – the ability to do many tasks at once. Multitasking shows that someone is capable, right? Wrong. 'Multitasking' is just switching from one task to another very quickly – it doesn't mean you've done any of the tasks particularly well. In fact, studies have shown that it can be quite the opposite. Working **in the way** not only tires the mind, but also prevents deep and original thought because switching from task to task means you have to start from beginning each other. In other words, it is for many a really ineffective way of getting things done and reduces the quality of the work we produce.

Constant use of information technology is another thing that affects our intelligence. 'Just Google it', has become the answer to every question. Having unlimited information at the click of a button, whenever you are, isn't as good for you as you might think. Sure, it's great to research a school project from the comfort of your own home – no need to go to the library! But original thinking goes out the window if you can just 'take' what you need from an online source without checking your sources. You are repeating other people's ideas without questioning them and you are not thinking critically. Technically, it is also stealing, but that's another story.

Finally, let's look at the negative effects of reality TV. There are countless shows about singing contests, celebrity families, pawn shops, the rich, the poor, and everyone in between. Are they quality TV? Generally speaking, no. Do they make us dumber? Quite possibly, yes. A study by psychologists involved showing a group of volunteers a fake reality show based around the life of a football hooligan, and then asking them to take a general knowledge test. What did the results reveal? Those who had seen the reality show before the test did worse than those who had not. As they say, 'Garbage in, garbage out'.

If you think you're a candidate for stupidity, here's what you can do: put down that burger, focus on one task at a time, think with your brain not with Google, and stop watching rubbish TV. You may even like the new you.

1. What is the writer's purpose in the first paragraph?

- (A) To describe our modern life
- (B) To say we are going back to the past
- (C) To make us aware of a problem
- (D) To show that the experts are right

2. According to the writer, junk food can

- (A) Motivate people to watch TV
- (B) Make some people very happy
- (C) Make people less interesting
- (D) Make you unhappy

3. What does 'in the way' mean?

- (A) Being busy
- (B) Doing many tasks at once
- (C) Beginning a job well
- (D) Working while you are tired

4. What do multitasking and googling have in common?

- (A) They prevent us from concentrating

- (B) They affect our ability to have new ideas

- (C) They help us to work faster
- (D) They make us lazier

5. What is the message in the paragraph about reality TV?

- (A) Intelligence can be affected by poor quality TV
- (B) Although it's called 'reality TV', It's often fake
- (C) There are too many different reality TV shows
- (D) Football hooligans are stupid

6. What does the writer NOT mention as a way to avoid stupidity?

- (A) Watch less television
- (B) Stop eating junk food
- (C) Do more voluntary work
- (D) Stop multi-tasking

Question 7-11 are about the following story about Sophie.

I'm sure I'm not the only person my age (15) who hates going to the dentist. Channel 4's late-night documentary Open wide last Tuesday was excellent for people like me. However, none of my school friends watched it. They missed this opportunity to see something interesting and educational because the program didn't appear in the TV Guide. This was a pity, as it was the type of program that makes both young people and their parents think about things they don't normally consider. Why can't television companies let us know about such important documentaries in advance?



This program was important because it showed how methods for helping people with toothache have developed over the centuries. If you think visiting the dentist today is an uncomfortable experience, just be grateful you didn't live 200 years ago! Then, the program told us, the only cure for toothache was removing the tooth. There weren't any dentists, so the person who cut your hair also pulled out your bad teeth, and there was nothing to stop you feeling the pain.

The program has also completely changed my attitude to looking after my teeth. My parents were always saying to me things like, 'don't eat too many sweets', and, 'brush your teeth after meals', but I never paid much attention. Now I've seen what damage sugar can do, especially if I don't use a toothbrush regularly, I'm going to change my habits. Many people would benefit from a repeat of this program.

7. Why has Sophie written this letter?

- (A) To complain about the time a television program was shown
- (B) To ask for more television programs designed for school children
- (C) To advise people to watch a particular television program
- (D) To persuade a television company to show a program again

8. Why didn't Sophie's school friends see Open wide?

- (A) They didn't know it was on
- (B) They don't enjoy that type of program
- (C) Their parents wouldn't let them
- (D) It wasn't shown on a channel they can receive

9. What did Open wide say about toothache?

- (A) In the past, nobody could make it stop
- (B) Dentists used to help people who had it
- (C) Hairdressers have it more than other people

(D) Ways of curing it have changed

10. What does Sophie think about her parents now?

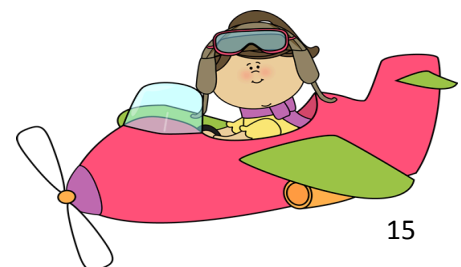
- (A) They don't know as much as her about teeth
- (B) Their advice is worth listening to
- (C) They eat things which are bad for them
- (D) They don't clean their teeth often enough

11. Which of these gives information about the program Sophie watched?

- (A) A play about a 19th century dentist and how he brought comfort to his patients
- (B) The series about health care for teenagers. This week, good eating habits
- (C) This history of the dentist's profession shows what happens when we eat
- (D) We suggest how to prepare young children for that first visit to the dentist

Questions 12-16 are about the following story about Bertrand Piccard and his co-pilot Brian Jones.

I learnt to fly in a balloon in a race across the Atlantic Ocean in 1992 and became fascinated by the sport. In the same way that a



mountain climber dreams of climbing the world's highest mountain, I dreamed about flying non-stop around the world.

I spent six years planning the flight and failed twice before we managed to succeed. Our route took us over China, but we could only get permission to travel over the south. This meant going first to North Africa to catch the right winds. That added 10,000 kilometers, and another week, to our journey. But because of this, our flight broke all the records for distance and time spent in the air.

My main memory of the trip is that we lived in the air for 20 days and that the rising sun was the most amazing thing we saw. We had to go out of the balloon's capsule, in which we were transported, three times while in the air to repair the fuel system. We didn't have any safety equipment but when you are in a situation like that, you just do what you have to do without thinking about feeling afraid.

Landing was a fantastic moment. I remember that when I got out of the capsule, I looked at my footprint in the sand. I remembered the astronaut Neil Armstrong who was so happy to put his footprint on the moon, so far away from Earth. At the moment, I was so happy to have my foot back on Earth!

12. What is Bertrand Piccard's main reason for writing this text?

- (A) To compare the sport of ballooning with mountain climbing
- (B) To recommend ballooning as a means of transport
- (C) To describe the lessons that failure has taught him
- (D) To report on succeeding at something he'd dreamt of for years

13. Why did the balloon fly over south China?

- (A) The wind took it in the wrong direction
- (B) The pilots weren't allowed to cross any other part
- (C) The pilots were running out of time
- (D) That route made the journey shorter

14. Why did the pilots get out of the capsule during the flight?

- (A) To practice what to do in an emergency
- (B) To check the safety equipment was working

- (C) To mend something which had a fault

- (D) To test their courage in a dangerous situation

15. How does Piccard say he felt when he landed?

- (A) Pleased to see a sign that he'd returned to Earth
- (B) Proud to be told he was like Neil Armstrong
- (C) Not able to stand or walk properly
- (D) Like an astronaut returning from the moon

16. What was the newspaper headline after the balloon landed?

- (A) Balloon pilot flies alone around the world
- (B) Non-stop from North Africa to China
- (C) Magnificent record flight for Piccard and Jones
- (D) New record – 10,000 km in a week

Questions 17-21 are about a boy who has done these things at a younger age than most people.

The most difficult thing for university student Shaun Rogers is opening his classroom door. Shaun can't do this without help because he's only six years old. He is the youngest person ever to study at Rochester University in New York. Shaun began reading at two, and by four was knowledgeable about a range of subjects from astronomy to zoology. By the age of five, he was regularly corresponding with university professors about his ideas. He has just completed his first book which will be published in a few months, shortly after his seventh birthday. 'I love learning,' says Shaun. 'My hero is the scientist Albert Einstein because he never combed his hair or wore socks.' Psychologists have found it difficult to test Shaun's intelligence because it goes beyond what they usually measure. Shaun's mother first realized her son was different when he kept crying at playschool because he was bored with the children's games. She started teaching him at home after finding that local schools were not prepared for children who learnt at Shaun's speed. Now Shaun is studying geography at Rochester University and using the Internet to complete his high school studies.

However, some psychologists warn that too much study can prevent a child from developing normally. 'I don't care how brilliant the kid is, six-year-olds have to play with their friends,' says Dr. Brian Wood. Mrs. Rogers disagrees that her son's time is completely taken up by school work. 'He loves the violin and has many outdoor interests, such as camping, fishing and swimming, just like other boys his age.'

17. What is the writer trying to do in the test?

- (A) Advice parents about their children's education
- (B) Compare the development of normal and clever children
- (C) Encourage students to enter university at a young age
- (D) Interest people in the life of an unusual child

18. How old was Shaun when he wrote his first book?

- (A) Four
- (B) Five
- (C) Six
- (D) Seven

19. Why did Shaun's mother decide to educate him at home?

- (A) Because she couldn't find a suitable school for him
- (B) Because his school wouldn't let him use the Internet
- (C) Because his teachers were unkind and made him cry
- (D) Because he didn't get on with the other children

20. What does Dr. Wood think about Shaun?

- (A) He isn't really any cleverer than other six-years-olds
- (B) He should spend more time having fun with other children
- (C) He will have to study harder to succeed at university
- (D) He can help his friends to do better at school

21. Which of these is Mrs. Rogers talking about Shaun?

- (A) 'My son gets bored easily if he doesn't have other children to play games or go swimming with him'
- (B) 'My son loves his studies and fortunately there are many children

of his own age in his class who share his interests'

- (C) 'What makes my son different from other children is that he started studying earlier and learns things much more quickly'
- (D) 'Like most young boys, my son often looks untidy and spends more time using the Internet than doing his homework'

Question 22-26 Refer to the following article.

Many people have noticed those neon green and white cars around big cities, with the unmistakable hot pink logo on the driver's side door stating: Hipcars. It's a car-sharing company that many young people have taken to like wildfire.

The question that competing rental-car companies may have is why the liberal-minded youth of today seem to love this successful and profitable business so much. Well, the program is based on a 'community of trust' **notion**, where a renter must have faith in the person who rented the car before them. No one is policing these vehicles to check the fuel levels and what state of cleanliness they are in.

The way it works is that a member can arrive at any public parking lot where a corner of the lot is owned by Hipcars. The member can choose the car they like, and drive it for as long as they need, by simply logging in the license number online. Hipcars can then track its vehicles by GPS. Before returning the car to any Hipcars lot, the member is responsible for throwing away all litter, wiping up all spills, and filling up the gas tank. Of course if any member does not meet these obligations, he or she is immediately reported by the next person driving the car. After three such incidences of negligence, the person's membership is canceled.

Hipcars is now being copied by many other car-rental agencies with more recognizable names, but it still stands out as the most successful of these firms. Many attitudes this fact to the company was the first to come up with this idea and market it almost exclusively to young people. After all, who needs to pay for insurance and various other car-ownership expenses, when a Hipcar is just around the corner, waiting for a budget-conscious customer to take it for a spin?

22. In the article, the word 'notion' in paragraph 2, line 3, is closest in meaning to

- (A) Noise
- (B) Idea
- (C) Applause
- (D) Letter

23. According to the article, why is this business 'based on trust'?

- (A) People know that their car is tracked by GPS
- (B) People trust the police to watch their rental car

- (C) People are responsible for cleaning the cars themselves
- (D) People trust the owners of the company

24. Why do people believe Hipcars to be the most successful company to do a car-share program?

- (A) It is owned by young people
- (B) It is affordable
- (C) It is environmentally friendly
- (D) It was their idea first

25. According to the article, who should become a member of Hipcars?

- (A) People who own stock in the company
- (B) Politically conscientious people
- (C) People on a budget
- (D) People under 21

26. What effect will this article most likely have on readers?

- (A) Make them buy a car
- (B) Make them sign up for Hipcars
- (C) Make them sell their car
- (D) Make them buy stock in Hipcars

Question 27-31 Refer to the following text.

Linda Hurley, one of her school's champion basketball players, says the morning is not a problem for her. Today she tells us her tips for happy mornings.

- I pack my schoolbag in the morning, so I don't look for my English book at 7.45 in the morning.
- I never get up late. You need time to enjoy your morning. I get up at six every day.
- I have a shower. It makes me up and it's fun.
- I enjoy the first drink of the day. It can be coffee, tea or orange juice. I always listen to music as I have that first drink. You can also read or watch the news.
- I sit down and have a proper breakfast – not a banana on the bus to school! It's really important. You need your breakfast.
- I usually walk to school or go for a walk with my brother's dog. I spend twenty to thirty minutes in the fresh air every morning before school – it's great!

27. Linda is

- (A) A teacher at the school
- (B) A sport girl
- (C) A coach for a basketball team

28. Linda gets ready for school

- (A) In the morning
- (B) In the afternoon
- (C) In the evening

29. As she has her morning drink, Linda

- (A) Listens to music
- (B) Reads

(C) Watches the news

30. Linda has breakfast

- (A) At home
- (B) On the bus
- (C) At school

31. Before school Linda always

- (A) Takes her dog for a walk
- (B) Goes for a walk with her brother
- (C) Spends some time outdoors

Question 32-37 Refer to the following text.

There is a world water crisis and we want people to know about it. We also want to raise money for our organization, Cycle for Water. It provides clean, safe water for towns and villages in Central and South America. We've carried a bottle of water from the Arctic all the way! At the end of the trip, we plan to pour it into the Antarctic.

We've met so many wonderful people! People have invited us to stay in their homes, given us food, laughed with us and shared our story. When we were in San Francisco, CNN asked us to go on their news show – that was really cool too. We also went to visit one of our water projects in San Juan La Laguna in Guatemala. It was fantastic to see the difference it makes to people's lives.

The beginning of the trip was really tough because we didn't train before we started and it was hard work pulling a heavy trainer behind our bikes. There were also millions of mosquitoes, dogs chased us and Michael's bike broke. Luckily, after a few weeks things got much better!

We've got bamboo bikes. The frame is bamboo, not metal. It's very strong and flexible so you don't feel the bumps in the road. They're really comfortable bikes to ride and they're environmentally friendly.

When you travel by bike, you meet people more quickly than you do when you are in a car or a coach. It is the best way to experience a place and you don't harm the environment in any way. It's a great way to learn about how people live and to learn about the world.

32. Michael and Joost

- (A) Have been to the Antarctic
- (B) Have been to the Arctic
- (C) Have reached Ushuaia.

33. One of the reasons for their trip is

- (A) To cycle from the Arctic to the Antarctic
- (B) To visit towns and villages in South America
- (C) To tell the world about the problems of getting clean water

34. During the trip

- (A) They have stayed in people's homes
- (B) They have visited many different water projects
- (C) They appeared on television in Guatemala

35. Before the trip started

- (A) Michael had a problem with his bike
- (B) They didn't practice at all
- (C) They practiced hard

36. Their bikes are good

- (A) Because they are comfortable to ride
- (B) But they feel all the bumps in the road
- (C) Because the frame is metal

37. They say that travelling by bike is

- (A) Much slower than going by car
- (B) Not as interesting as going by coach
- (C) A good way to meet people

Question 38-42 Refer to the following text.

Have you ever seen a hitchhiker standing by the side of a road? Hitchhiking is popular with young people because it doesn't cost anything – drivers stop and take you on all or part of your journey. Of course, it's not like a bus or train because it can take a long time, but hitchhikers say they meet some amazing people. Now drivers in Canada might see an unusual hitchhiker – Hitchbot, a hitchhiking robot. One of its inventors, David Harris Smith, has hitched across Canada three times and says he had some of the best experiences of his life. Smith and a colleague, Frauke Zeller, have built Hitchbot because they wanted to see if people would stop and give the robot a lift and talk to it. The robot can chat about things it has learnt, about its inventors and about its journey. It has access to Wikipedia and it runs on solar power. You might think it's a joke, but Smith and Zeller's experiment has a serious point – can robots and people get on together?

Hitchbot's journey started in Nova Scotia in July. It has already completed a third of its 6,000 mile journey to Victoria. It's now near Lake Superior. More than 57,000 people are following its journey on Facebook and Twitter and travelers have posted lots of photos on the website. Hitchbot has also done some shopping, eaten motor oil and had fun with travelers. Nobody knows when it will finish its journey – Zeller and Smith want Hitchbot to get as many rides as possible. It hasn't been in a self-driving car yet, but anything is possible!

38. Hitchhiking isn't like travelling by bus or train because it's

- (A) Free
- (B) Quicker
- (C) Boring

39. When Smith hitchhiked, he

- (A) Didn't have a good time
- (B) Had some incredible experiences
- (C) Took a long time to travel across Canada

40. Hitchbot

- (A) Can't talk about many things
- (B) Can only describe its inventors
- (C) Can talk about many different things

41. Hitchbot

- (A) Has nearly completed its journey
- (B) Has completed about 2,000 miles
- (C) Has already travelled 57,000 miles

42. Hitchbot hasn't

- (A) Been to any shops
- (B) Posted photos on the website
- (C) Had fun